

CSCE 632 ACCESSIBLE COMPUTING · MODULE 13 · LECTURE NOTES

Claiming Something Is Accessible

What you tested, and what you did not.

MODULE OUTCOMES

- State what an accessibility claim establishes.
- Identify the standard overclaims.
- Write an honest accessibility statement.
- Place this course in the semester and the program.
- State a proportionate practice you will actually keep.

1 What a claim establishes

AN ACCESSIBILITY CLAIM ESTABLISHES THAT THESE CRITERIA, TESTED THIS WAY, BY THESE PEOPLE, AT THIS TIME, PASSED

Which criteria — the level claimed, and whether every criterion at and below that level was actually checked, since **conformance is all-or-nothing per page and per complete process** (Module 07 §2).

Tested how — **automated only**, which covers about a third of the criteria; or **manually by somebody competent**; or **with the actual assistive technology** (Module 09 §1) — **which are wildly different claims routinely expressed in the same words.**

By whom — and in particular whether anybody who uses assistive technology daily was involved (Module 09 §4) — **which no conformance level requires and which largely determines the claim's value.**

And when — **because an audit is a snapshot and the interface has shipped eleven times since** (Module 09 §4's cadence point). **'It's accessible'** asserts all four of these and specifies none of them, which is why it is not a claim so much as a sentiment.

The claim	The correction
'It's accessible.'	Which criteria, tested how, by whom, and when? (§1.)
'Our checker reports zero errors.'	Which covers roughly a third of the criteria, and none of the judgement calls (Module 09 §1).
'We're AA conformant.'	Every page? Every complete process, end to end? (Module 07 §2.)
'We tested it with a screen reader.'	You did, or a daily user did? Those are not the same test (Module 09 §4).

The claim	The correction
'No users have complained.'	The excluded are absent from your data by construction (Module 02 §2) — see the note.
'It's accessible but not WCAG compliant.'	Entirely possible (Module 09 §3 runs the other way too) — and it needs exactly the evidence the claim skipped.

'No users have complained' is the one to refuse hardest — the people excluded by the interface are structurally absent from the channel through which complaints arrive, because the complaint form is part of the interface. The no-complaints claim is the commonest and the emptiest, and Module 02 §2's survivorship argument is the complete answer to it, delivered as a technical objection rather than a reproach.

2 The statement

THE TARGET

which standard, which level, and whether the whole product or named parts of it

THE STATUS

conformant, partially conformant, or non-conformant -- and "partially" is the honest answer almost always

THE KNOWN EXCEPTIONS, NAMED

"the data export dialog is not keyboard accessible; a fix is planned for Q3"
which is the clause that makes the rest of the statement credible

HOW IT WAS TESTED

the methods, who ran them, and whether disabled participants were involved
(Module 09 section 4)

WHEN

the date of the assessment, and the cadence of reassessment

AND A ROUTE IN

a contact who answers, which is the part that actually changes outcomes

BECAUSE THE GAP BETWEEN CONFORMANCE AND USABILITY HAS TO BE STATED, NOT IMPLIED

A fully conformant interface may be unusable (Module 09 §3's five examples) **and a non-conformant one may be perfectly usable for every real task** — so the conformance level alone is a weak signal about the thing anybody actually cares about.

Which means the useful statement is about tasks rather than criteria: 'these five tasks have been completed independently by assistive technology users' is a far stronger and more informative claim than any conformance level, and is also harder to fake.

And the route in is what actually fixes things over time — a contact who answers converts an excluded user into a defect report, which is Module 12 §4's most effective lever and costs a mailbox somebody reads.

So the statement's job is to be honest and actionable rather than reassuring — and **a statement with no named exceptions is a statement nobody checked**, which is how a careful reader should treat one.

3 The semester and the program

Course	The measurement it introduces	What it replaces
CSCE 671	Five participants attempting a real task, observed.	'This feels intuitive.'
CSCE 679	The measured ranking of the visual channels.	'This chart looks good.'
CSCE 632 (this one)	The actual assistive technology, and a published standard.	'This seems accessible.'

All three courses correct the same error: designing for an imagined user who resembles the designer — and **all three correct it with an observation rather than an argument**, which is why the semester's three closing modules arrive at the same shape. **This is the semester's result, stated from the third course:** the common structure is cheap measurement in place of confident intuition, and in each case the measurement takes minutes and the intuition was wrong.

4 A practice you will keep

- 1 · **Unplug the mouse before you commit** (Module 05 §2) — **the highest-yield thirty seconds in the course**, and the one that will survive being busy.
- 2 · **Open the accessibility pane while you are building each control** (Module 08 §1) — **role, name, value, state** — which is a specification rather than a test.
- 3 · **Use the native element** (Module 08 §2) — **which is less code and more correct**, and is therefore the easiest habit on this list to keep.
- 4 · **Put an automated checker in continuous integration** (Module 09 §1) — **for the regressions, which is its real value** rather than for the initial findings.
- 5 · **And ask the question in design review** (Module 12 §1) — **because that is the only point at which it is free. Only step 5 changes the cost: the other four find defects, and the fifth prevents the decisions that make them expensive** (Module 12 §3).

WHERE THIS COURSE LEAVES YOU

You can state a requirement from a capability and test it in minutes — which is what makes this engineering rather than advocacy, and is the whole structure of Modules 03 through 06: a constraint, a requirement, and a test you can run today.

You know the mechanism — the accessibility tree, and name-role-value-state — so most of the rules are derivable rather than recalled (Module 08 §4), which is the difference between knowing this subject and having read about it.

And you know what a conformance claim is worth, and why this subject's failure is organisational rather than technical (Modules 07, 09, and 12) — **which is the part most accessibility courses omit** and the part that determines whether any of the rest happens.

The closing rule is the program's, unchanged across thirty-three courses: state what you measured, state what you assumed, and never claim more than you established. In this subject it is the accessibility statement with its exceptions named — because 'it's accessible' claims everything and establishes nothing, and the named exception is the only part of such a statement a reader can rely on.

Where to see this taught differently

Original material only goes so far — hearing the same idea in another voice is how it sticks. These are free, and they cover this module specifically.

Resource	What it covers for this module
The W3C accessibility statement generator (free)	§2 — a template that asks for all six parts, including the exceptions and the contact route.
WCAG conformance claims and the understanding documents (free)	§1 — what a conformance claim must contain to be one at all, which is more than most claims contain.
The WebAIM Million, read as a claims audit (free)	§1's overclaims at scale — compare stated accessibility policies against measured detectable defects.
Lazar et al. — Research Methods in Human-Computer Interaction, the accessibility chapters	§1's 'by whom' , done properly — including recruitment and compensation. Library copy.

Exercises

Do these in code, not on paper, unless the exercise says otherwise. The module is not finished until they run.

- 1 State the four parts of a claim** for something you have built.
- 2 Find three published accessibility claims** and assess each against §1.

- 3 **Correct six overclaims** you have personally heard or made.
- 4 **Answer 'no users have complained'** in four sentences.
- 5 **Write a full accessibility statement** with all six parts, for your Project 2 work.
- 6 **Make the exceptions list specific**, with dates.
- 7 **Rewrite one criteria-based claim** as a task-based one.
- 8 **Set up a contact route** and decide who answers it.
- 9 **State each Semester 11 course's measurement** and what it replaces.
- 10 **Project 2 is now due.** Submit the repairs with their mechanism justifications, the before-and-after assistive technology transcripts, the 400% reflow case, the non-visual representation, the remaining-defects list, and the one repair that improved the interface for everybody.

Self-check

Answer these in writing, from memory, without looking back at the notes. If you cannot, you have read this module but not yet learned it — that is useful information, not a failure.

- 1 Give the four parts of an accessibility claim.
- 2 Why is 'it's accessible' not a claim?
- 3 Correct six standard overclaims.
- 4 Why is the no-complaints claim empty, and what answers it?
- 5 Give the six parts of an honest statement.
- 6 Why do the named exceptions carry the credibility?
- 7 Why is a task-based claim stronger than a criteria-based one?
- 8 What does a route in actually accomplish?
- 9 State each Semester 11 course's measurement and what it replaces.
- 10 Give the five practices, and say which one changes the cost.